

PLANT PEST



Chris Anderson, NSW DPI.

Texas root rot

Exotic to Australia

Features: Soil borne fungal disease that causes sudden wilt and death in many plant species.

Where it's from: Southwest USA, Mexico, Venezuela, and recently reported in Libya, North Africa.

How it spreads: Importation of infected plants or soil; local spread through infected plants, water and soil.

At risk: Thousands of plant species; cotton, grapes, fruit trees, forest trees, alfalfa, cherry, grains, soybean, lucerne and ornamental plants.

This pest is listed on both the National Priority Plant Pests and the [National Priority List of Exotic Environmental Pests, Weeds and Diseases](#) as it has the potential for significant plant industry/agriculture impacts and may also cause significant damage to our environment and social amenity.

Keep it out

Texas root rot, caused by the fungus *Phymatotrichopsis omnivora*, is one of the most destructive fungal plant diseases. It is a soil-borne fungus that attacks the roots of plants, causing them to wilt and die, usually during the warmer months.

Texas root rot affects over 2000 species of plants including vegetable, fruit and broadacre crops. It is an important disease of cotton as well as grapes, fruit trees and many ornamental plants.

It is very difficult to control Texas root rot once it gets into fields or orchards because it penetrates deep into the soil and survives there for a long time. It has been known to lie dormant for decades, so that only other species that are resistant to the disease can be grown.

Importing goods

To keep Texas root rot out of Australia, never ignore Australia's strict biosecurity rules.

Import shipments may need to be treated and certified, so before you import, check our [Biosecurity Import Conditions system \(BICON\)](#).

What to look for

- Plants wilting and dying, particularly during hot weather as the rotted roots are unable to take up enough water.
- The roots of infected plants will be covered with a network of white to tan fungal strands.
- In the field, look for patches of dead and dying plants, often with the dead leaves still attached. Patches may expand in a circular pattern during warm weather as the fungus spreads through the soil from plant to plant. You might see a spore mat on the soil around infected plants.



Roots of dead plants are covered in fungal strands.
S.D. Lyda, Bugwood.org.



Dead cotton plants with leaves still attached.

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Where to look

Importers

Infected plants, plant material and soil are the most likely way that Texas root rot could make it to Australia.

Growers and home gardeners

Check plants or crops for wilting and root damage, particularly in summer. It affects agricultural crops like:

- cotton
- grapes, especially *Vitis vinifera* varieties
- forest trees
- grain crops
- cherry
- mango
- avocado
- corn
- peach
- pecan
- fruit trees
- ornamental plants

What to do

If you think you've found Texas root rot:

- take a photo
- do not disturb infected plants (this may be as simple as closing the doors on a shipping container or preventing access to a field).

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/pests-diseases-weeds/plant/identify/texas-root-rot>